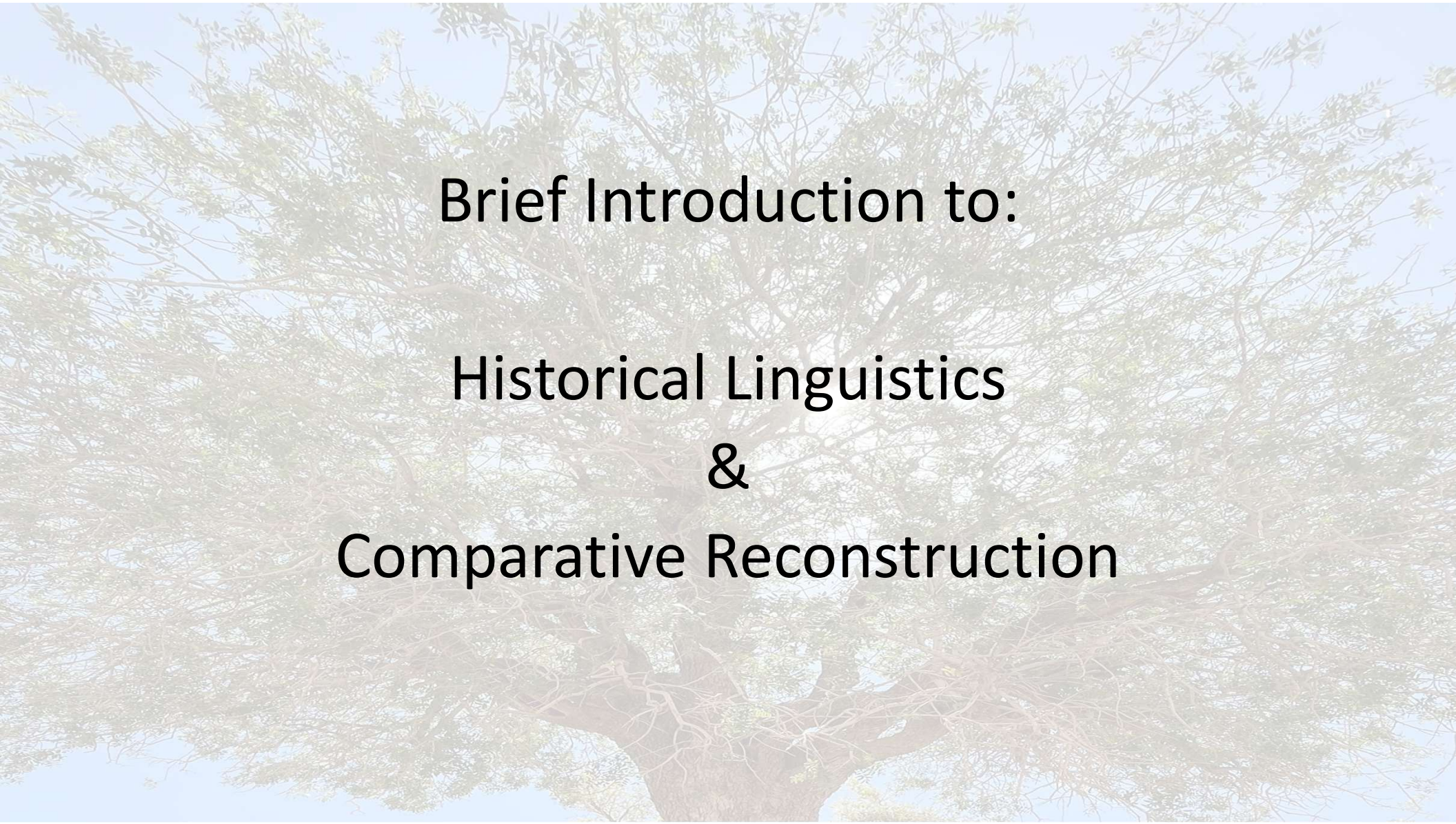
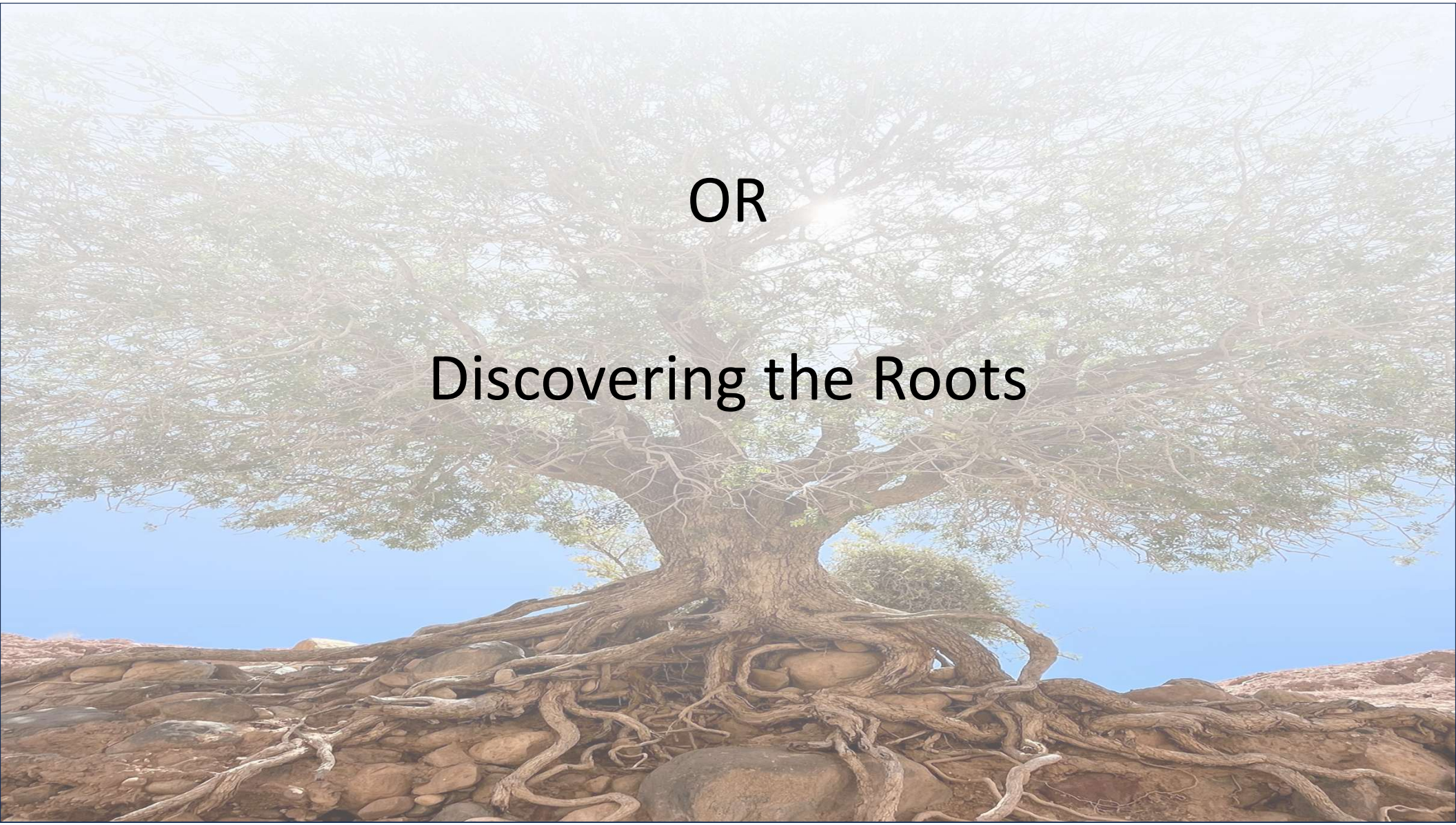


Brief Introduction to:

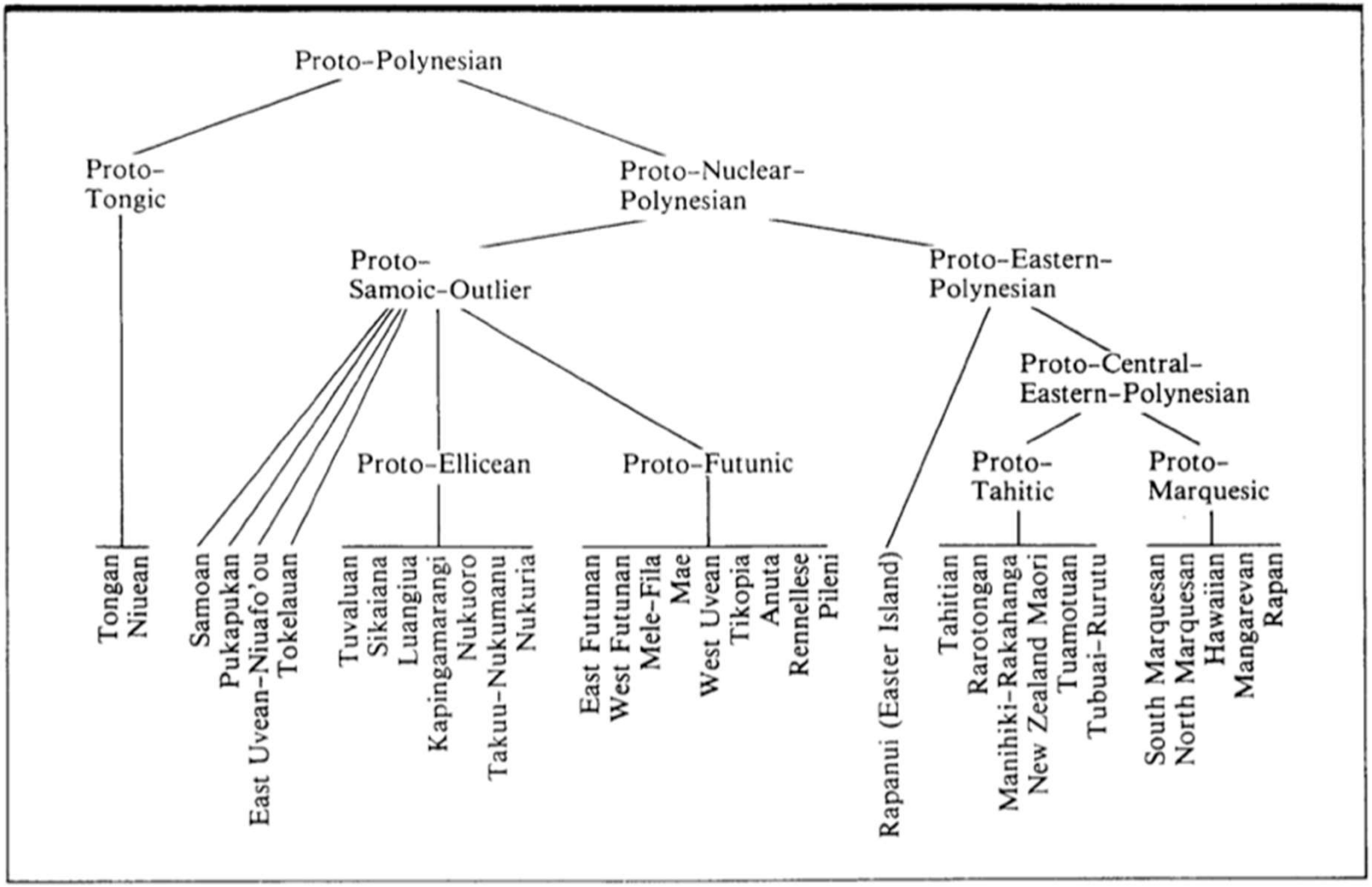
Historical Linguistics
&
Comparative Reconstruction



OR

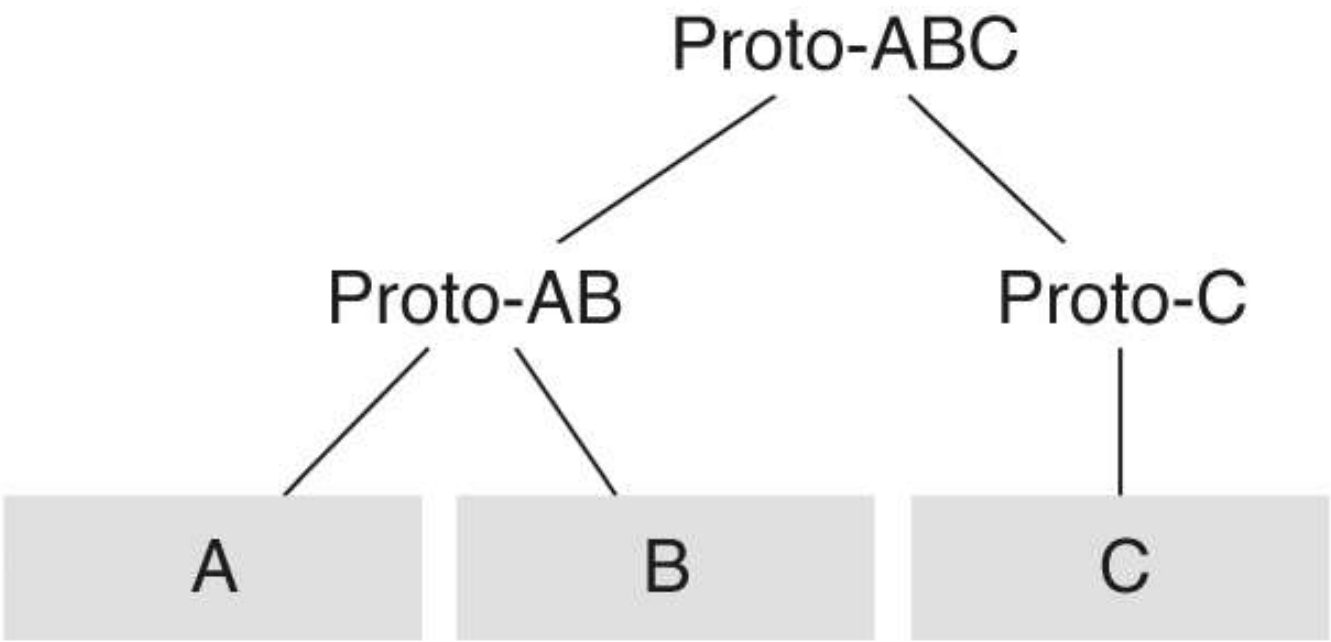
Discovering the Roots

FIGURE 1. *Internal Relationships of Polynesian*



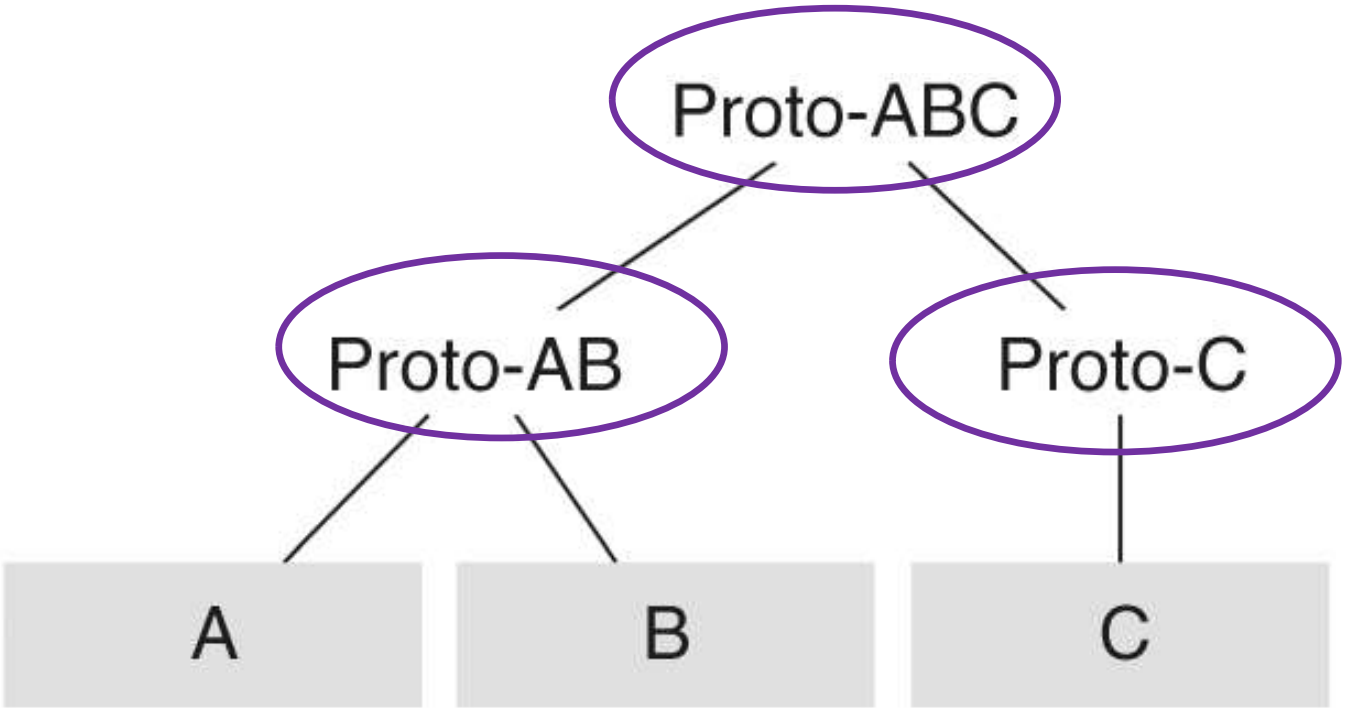
Tree from: Besnier, Niko. 1992. Polynesian languages. In *International Encyclopedia of Linguistics*, ed. by William Bright, Vol. 3, pp. 245-251. New York & Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Related Languages



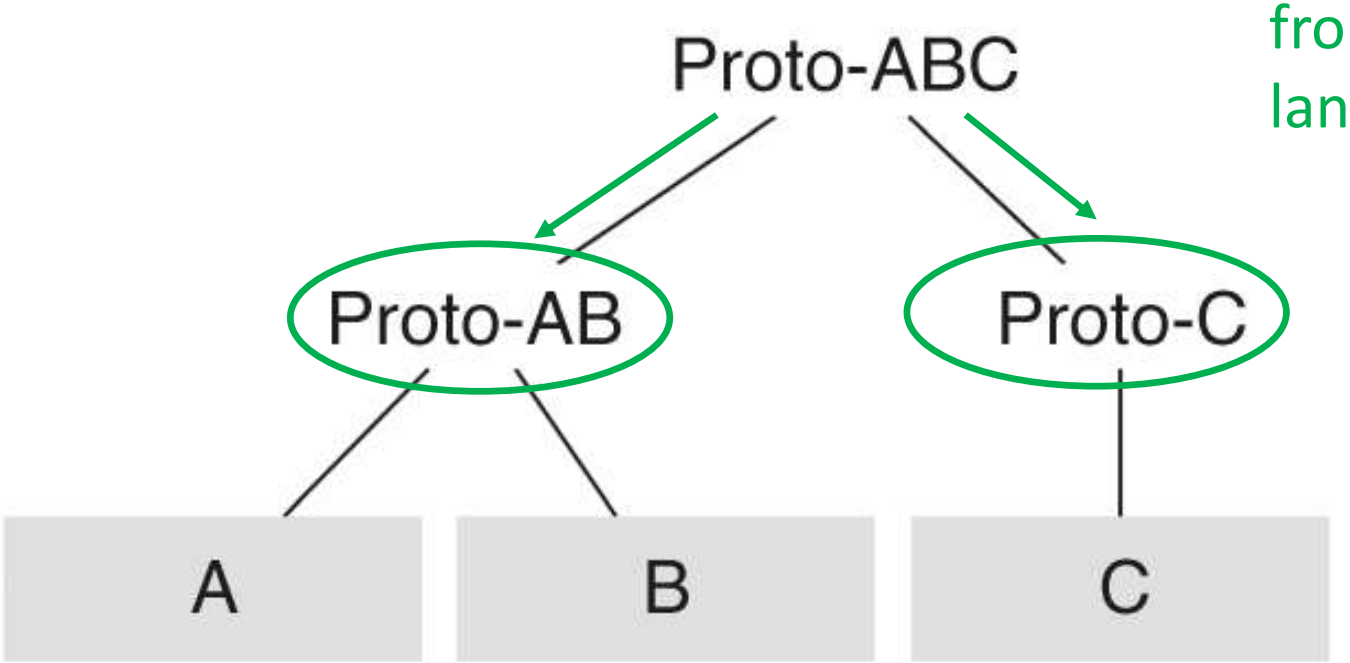
Related Languages

Proto = no direct evidence

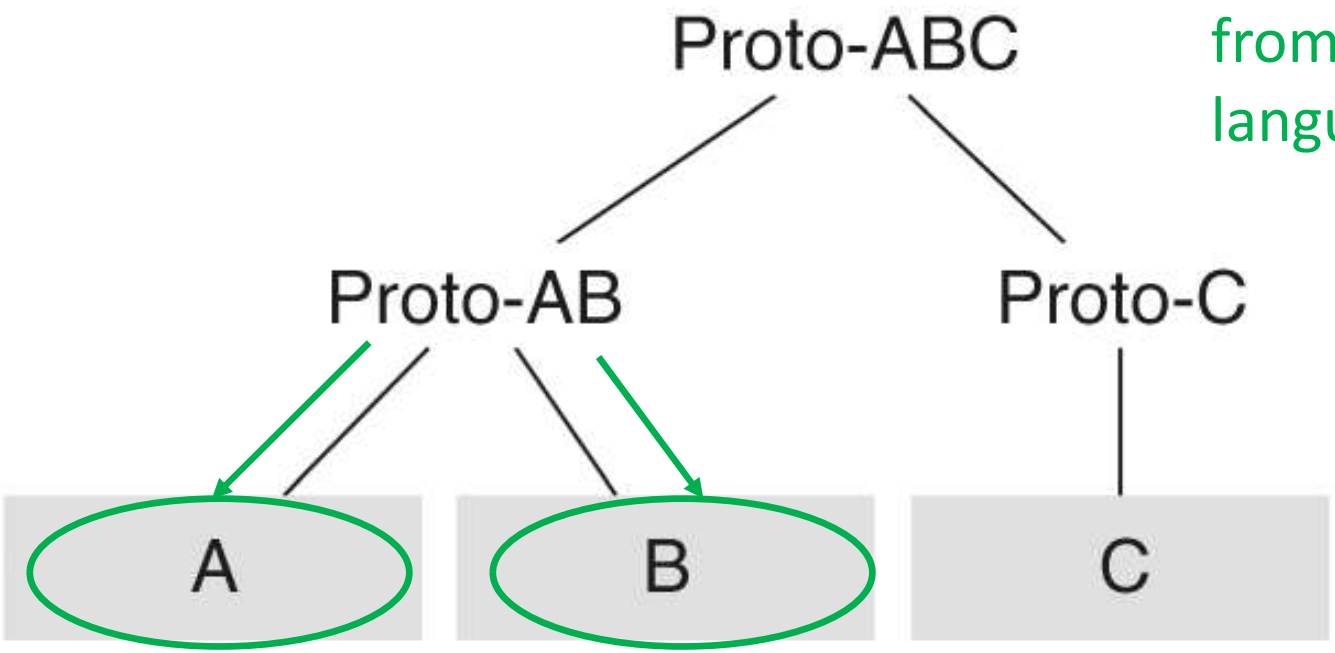


Related Languages

Daughters = come from the same language



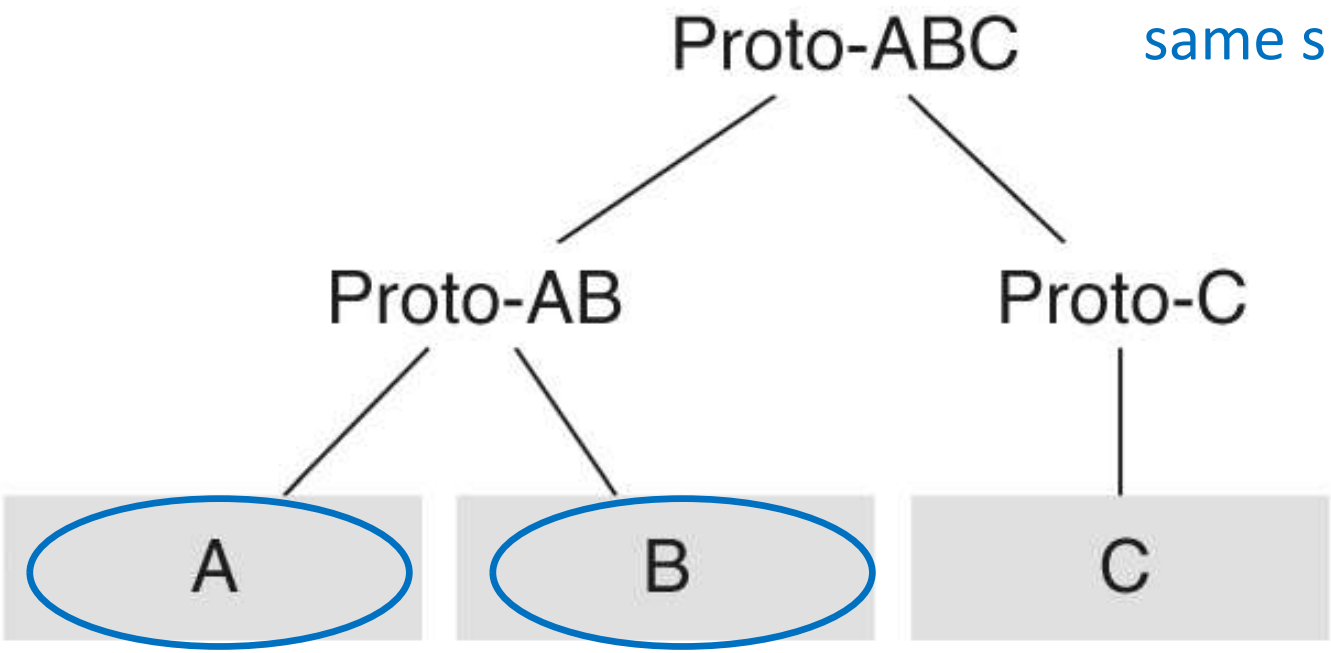
Related Languages



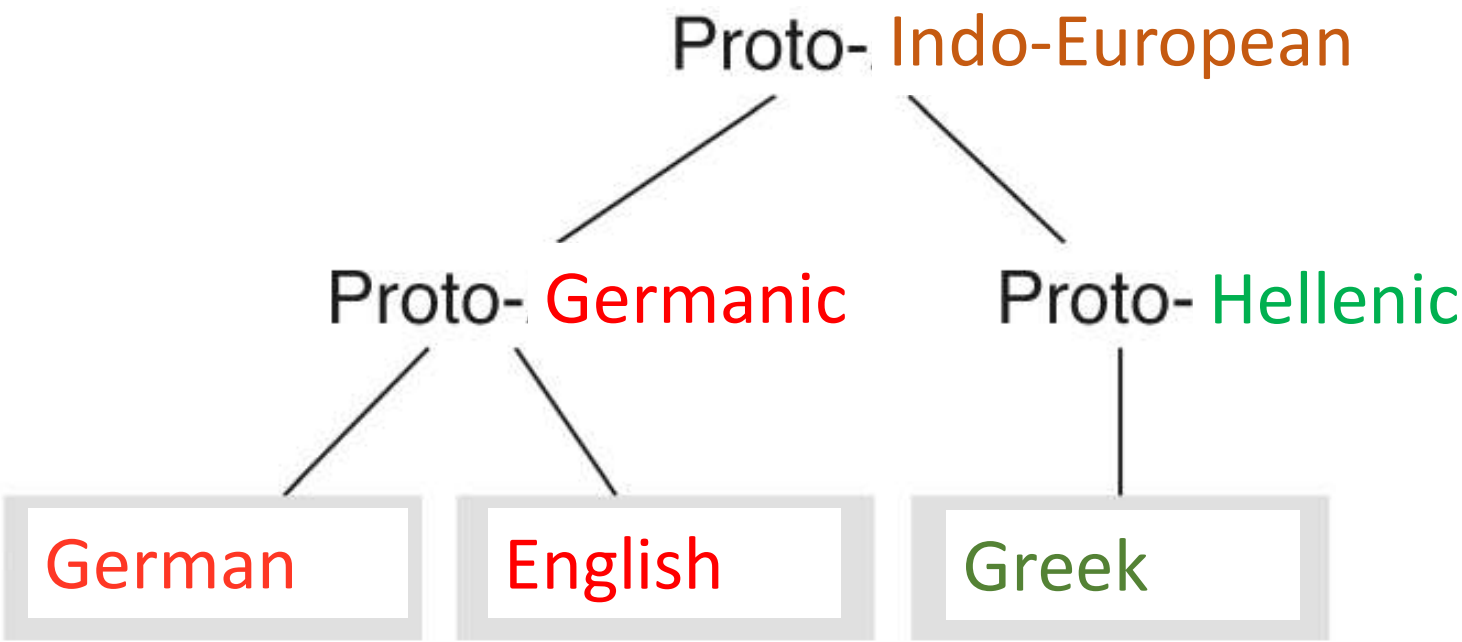
Daughters = come from the same language

Related Languages

Sisters = belong to the same subgroup



Related Languages



How do we Decide if Languages are Related?

Two or more languages that share a recent language ancestor will show similarities in pronunciation, syntactic structure, and/or words:

Spanish	Italian	Translation
leer	leggere	“read”
libritos	libretti	“little books”
gato	gatto	“cat”

Words like in the above example are called cognates

Cognates

Words from different languages that are similar in:

1. form
   - signed languages: look very similar
   - spoken languages: sounds very similar

   AND

2. meaning: have roughly the same meaning or a closely related meaning

How do we Decide if Languages are Related?

Finding some cognates is not enough evidence for establishing that languages are historically related (i.e., belong to the same family)

We need to be able to see clearer systematic differences and similarities across languages.

Language Reconstruction

Historical linguists can reconstruct an (unknown) proto-language by comparing cognates from the descendent languages and establishing systematic sound changes.

Comparative Reconstruction: older stages are predicted from two or more later stages of separated language communities (i.e., daughters or dialects)

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

We need to think of this process as fluid:

Step 1: Sort out those forms which appear to be cognate and ignore the non-cognate forms.

	Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian	
1.	tapu	tapu	tapu	kapu	'forbidden'

Meaning is similar

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Forms are similar

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 2: Write out the full set of sound correspondences between the languages you are looking at, including correspondences where the sounds are identical across all of them.

- Note correspondences where a sound in one language corresponds to Ø in another language

Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian
t	t	t	k
a	a	a	a
p	p	p	p
u	u	u	u

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 3: Group together all correspondences that have reflexes that are phonetically similar.

Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian
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a	a	a	a
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How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 4: Make an estimation about the original form of the phonemes, using the following criteria:

a. A sound that does not occur in any of the daughter languages should not be reconstructed (avoid overly “abstract” reconstructions), unless there are very good reasons for doing so.

Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian
t	t	t	k
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*tk

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~~*tk~~

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 4: Make an estimation about the original form of the phonemes, using the following criteria:

b. Naturalness principle: proposed original phoneme must be plausible!

Some common sound changes:

assimilation: sounds become more like one another (e.g., impossible, intolerable, illegal)

deletion/elision: sounds are lost (e.g., chocolate)

lenition: sounds become “weakened” or become more sonorous (e.g., water)

- plosives become taps, fricatives or affricates, voiceless sounds are voiced

metathesis: reordering of segments (e.g., waps > wasp, nuclear vs nucular)

merger: two sounds become one (e.g., caught/cot)

lengthening/shortening: sounds become longer or shorter

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 4: Make an estimation about the original form of the phonemes, using the following criteria:

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Some changes are more common than others

- assimilation more likely than dissimilation
- lenition is more likely than fortition
- merger is more likely that split
- deletion is often more likely that insertion

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 4: Make an estimation about the original form of the phonemes, using the following criteria:

b. Naturalness principle: proposed original phoneme must be plausible!

Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian
t	t	t	k
a	a	a	a
p	p	p	p
u	u	u	u

t?

k?

How to do Comparative Reconstructions?

Step 4: Make an estimation about the original form of the phonemes, using the following criteria:

c. Majority principle: the sound that has the widest distribution in the daughter languages is most likely to be the original phoneme. (Use with extreme caution!)

Tongan	Samoan	Rarotongan	Hawaiian	
t	t	t	k	*tapu
a	a	a	a	
p	p	p	p	*t > k
u	u	u	u	